

The Overthinker's Journal

The Overthinker's Journal

A Teen Guide to Quieting a Racing Mind

NORTH STAR JOURNALS

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This journal is intended for self-reflection and general well-being. It is not a substitute for professional mental-health care. If you are struggling, please reach out to a trusted adult, counselor, or crisis line. In the U.S., call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline). Outside the U.S., see findahelpline.com.

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For anyone whose brain refuses to close its tabs.

HOW TO USE THIS JOURNAL

This is your journal. Use it in whatever order helps. Skip pages. Come back to pages. Nothing here is a test.

There are five sections. Grounding tools you can use in the moment. Prompts to help you get thoughts out of your head and onto paper. Trackers to spot patterns. A toolkit of small practices. And eight weeks of short reflections.

Try one prompt when your mind is loud. Try one tracker for a week. If a page feels wrong for you today, turn to another one. Progress is not linear, and neither is this book.

There are no wrong answers here. Write in pencil, pen, whatever. Scribble. Draw. Leave pages blank. This journal will not grade you.

If your anxiety is getting in the way of your daily life, please also talk to a trusted adult or a mental-health professional. Resources are on the last page.

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SECTION ONE

Start Here

Five grounding tools you can use anywhere.

5-4-3-2-1

Look around. Name five things you can see. Four things you can touch. Three things you can hear. Two things you can smell. One thing you can taste. Go slow. Your senses pull you back into your body.

NOTES

BOX BREATHING

Breathe in for four counts. Hold for four. Breathe out for four. Hold for four. Repeat four times. Draw a square in the air with your finger as you breathe, one side per count.

NOTES

BODY SCAN

Start at the top of your head. Slowly move your attention down: forehead, jaw, shoulders, chest, belly, arms, hands, legs, feet. Notice what's tight. Let it soften if it wants to. If it doesn't, that's fine.

NOTES

COLD WATER RESET

Splash cold water on your face, or hold an ice cube for a few seconds, or run your wrists under cold water for thirty seconds. The temperature shift interrupts the anxiety loop and signals your nervous system to slow down.

NOTES

NAME IT TO TAME IT

Say out loud, or write down, exactly what you're feeling. “I feel anxious because...” Being specific about the emotion — not just ‘bad’ — shrinks it a little. Try to name three feelings if you can.

NOTES

SECTION TWO

Prompts

Get the loop out of your head and onto the page.

What thought have you been on a loop with today? Write it out until it runs out.

If your mind is a browser, how many tabs are open right now? Name them.

Which of your worries have you already thought about more than once this week?

What is a decision you've been re-deciding? What would 'good enough' look like?

Write down the worst-case scenario in full. Now write how you'd actually handle it.

What are you overthinking because you care? What are you overthinking out of fear?

Finish this: 'I keep thinking about it because...'

Which of your worries are you actually solving, and which are you just circling?

Write down every 'what if.' Then, next to each, write 'and then what?'

What conversation are you rehearsing in your head? Write the version you'd actually say.

What is one thing you cannot know right now, no matter how long you think about it?

What would it feel like to be done thinking about this for tonight?

Whose voice is loudest in your head when you spiral? Is it yours?

What's the story your brain keeps telling? What's a truer, kinder version?

Write the message you want to send, but don't send it. What did you learn?

Where do you feel the overthinking in your body? What do you notice?

What is the thing you're afraid to decide? Set a deadline for the decision.

What would you tell a friend who was thinking about this as hard as you are?

What has your overthinking never once solved for you? What has it cost?

What is one worry you can hand off — to tomorrow, to a friend, to no one at all?

Write down three worries. Rate each 1-10 for 'how likely is this, really?'

What would you do next if you trusted yourself to figure it out along the way?

What is a decision past-you made that turned out fine? How did that feel then?

What if the thing you're worried about isn't actually the point?

What is the smallest thing you could do right now to interrupt the loop?

What thought are you ready to be done with, at least for tonight?

Write about a time your overthinking was wrong. What actually happened?

Finish this: 'The version of me that isn't overthinking would...'

What does 'done thinking about it' look like tonight? Write yourself permission.

SECTION THREE

Trackers

Notice the patterns in your racing-thought episodes.

ANXIETY LEVEL THIS WEEK

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT TRIGGERED IT	WHAT HELPED
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SLEEP TRACKER

DAY	HOURS	HOW I SLEPT	HOW I FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

MOOD CHECK-IN

DAY	MORNING	AFTERNOON	NIGHT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

RACING-THOUGHT EPISODES LOG

DAY	WHERE / WHEN	BODY FEELING	WHAT I DID NEXT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

ENERGY THIS WEEK

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT DRAINED ME	WHAT REFILLED ME
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

ONE SMALL WIN

DAY	WIN OF THE DAY	WHO SAW IT	HOW IT FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

KINDNESS TO SELF

DAY	WHAT I DID	HOW IT FELT	DO AGAIN?
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

ANXIETY LEVEL THIS WEEK

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DAY	WHAT I DID	HOW IT FELT	DO AGAIN?
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Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SECTION FOUR

Your Toolkit

Small practices you can return to on hard days.

CLOSE THE TABS

List every open worry in your head like browser tabs. Star the ones worth keeping open. Close the rest by writing 'not today' next to them.

THE 10-10-10

Ask: Will this matter in 10 minutes? In 10 months? In 10 years? Write your honest answer to each. Notice how the size of the worry shifts.

WORRY WINDOW

Give yourself a 15-minute worry window. Set a timer. Write down everything your brain wants to worry about. When the timer ends, close the book.

NAME THE LOOP

Write the exact sentence your brain is stuck on. Read it out loud three times.

Ask: is this a fact, a fear, or a story?

THE NEXT TINY STEP

You do not need the whole plan. Write the single smallest next action. Do that. Come back to this page after.

REFRAME IT

Write the anxious thought at the top. Underneath, write what you would tell a friend who said this to you. Notice the tone difference.

PARK IT FOR TONIGHT

Write your worry on a page. Close the book. Tell yourself: 'It will still be here in the morning if I need it.' Try to leave it here.

WHAT I CAN CONTROL

Draw a small circle inside a bigger one. Small circle: what you can actually do. Big circle: what's outside your reach. Keep your attention in the small circle.

THE 5-MINUTE RULE

Pick the thing you've been avoiding by overthinking it. Set a timer for 5 minutes and start. Then stop. Write about what came up.

BODY FIRST

Overthinking is often a signal that your body needs something. Drink water, eat, move for five minutes, or step outside. Then check in.

AFFIRMATIONS

Write down phrases that feel true (or that you want to be true). Circle the ones that help most. Come back to them.

- I do not have to solve every thought.
- Not deciding is also a decision I can rest in.
- One clear next step is enough.
- My worry is not my future.
- I can put this down for tonight.
- I trust myself to figure it out as it comes.
- Overthinking is not the same as caring.
- I am allowed to close the tabs.

NOTES

SECTION FIVE

Weekly Reflections

Eight weeks of looking back and forward.

WEEK 1 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 1 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 2 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 2 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 3 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 3 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 4 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 4 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 5 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 5 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 6 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 6 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 7 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 7 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 8 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 8 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WHEN YOU NEED MORE HELP

This journal is for reflection, not treatment. If your anxiety is getting in the way of school, sleep, eating, friendships, or feeling safe, please talk to a trusted adult, a school counselor, or a therapist.

If you are in crisis:

- U.S. — Call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline).
- U.S. — Text HOME to 741741 (Crisis Text Line).
- U.K. — Call 116 123 (Samaritans).
- Global — findahelpline.com lists lines in your country.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call your local emergency number.

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